2 RR days came in handy. Whenever an operation is too 'clean' and carried out surreptitiously or in isolation without involving the local police, it immediately raises a 'Red' flag, of it being a staged encounter. Based on the preliminary inquiry, disciplinary action was initiated, and the officer was Court Martialled and sentenced to life imprisonment.[19] When I met the RM at 1030 hours on 17 September, I apprised him of this development, which was certain to make headlines. This was followed by a CSG meeting at 1230 hours the same day in preparation for the sixth SHCML meeting scheduled for later in the week.

It is against this backdrop that the sixth round was held on 21 September. In the CSG meeting held earlier, we had brainstormed on the way forward and what should be our negotiating strategy. The end-state was clear, a return to the status quo, but what should or could be the lines of operation leading to that end-state? There was no question of accepting a partial pullback. As the NSA, Shri Ajit Doval, pointed out, it is the Chinese strategy to come forward five steps, then go back one step and make it appear like a great concession, yet gaining ultimately. Incessantly creeping forward one step at a time, in classic 'salami-slicing' tactics. The EAM was also quite clear that we should not be in a hurry to accept any partial solution but continue to negotiate from a principled position. No doubt his experience as Foreign Secretary and, more importantly, as Ambassador to China, guided his thinking.[20] We also agreed that the principle of first-in-first-out, i.e., resolving the earlier issue first should be our strategy. During this round, while agreeing to take forward the five-point consensus reached by the Foreign Ministers, it was the PLA who changed their tune and started stressing the need for disengagement, now that the tactical advantage lay with us. This was a major shift in their stance. They were also not happy with the developments on the

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